DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

How Can Creation Give Joy to a God Who Lacks Nothing?

Daat Tevunot §58

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §58 (completing section 3), after finishing the revision of the summary of section 3 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 12 January 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Finishing the revision: two modes of God's rule

The class began by completing the revision of the summary of section 3 in the English edition (pages 136-138). Section 3 is about the time of concealment, when God relates to the world in two modes:

- **Hanhagat hamishpat**, the mode of justice: the everyday, default mode of sakhar veonesh, reward and punishment. "HaKadosh Barukh Hu's hands are tied", as it were, by the rules He set in His Torah.
- **Hanhagat hayihud**, the mode of unity: an override button.

The Rabbi gave a classroom example. A child misbehaves, and the rules say detention. But the teacher sees the glint in the child's eye, or the child is his own son, and he overrides the rule. That rarely happens, but it is possible.

Why is the override called "unity"? Because it shows sovereignty. God made a system and in a sense binds Himself to it, but since He is the source of everything He can override it at any time. The summary puts it this way: the attribute of judgment is revealed and visible, while the attribute of sovereignty and perfection acts on a hidden level within the judgment itself.

Perfection only relative to the world

The fourth paragraph of the summary raises the Neshamah's question: if God's perfection is utterly beyond the world, how can it act on the world and perfect it? The answer is that God created the world by withdrawing His infinite essence and bringing into being finite attributes to run it. What He sends into the world is perfection relative to the created world, not His true infinite perfection. "Concealment within concealment." God Himself will never be understood. The revelation at the end will be that emanation becoming complete, not God revealing His essence.

§58: nothing is a necessary existence

The group then returned to the Hebrew of §58, where they had stopped before the break. The Sekhel explains the saying of Hazal that God is the place of the world and the world is not His place.

The Rabbi noted that this is one of the principles in the first chapter of Derech Hashem: nothing except God is a necessary existence. Everything else exists only by His will, and is therefore at every moment dependent on His will. That is the meaning of the verses about the upper waters suspended by God's word, and of the Midrash that a human being is beneath what he carries, while God is above His burden: He supports existence from above.

So it is not that the world is a space for God, but that God gives the world its space to exist. He returned to his familiar analogy: a universe you imagine exists only as long as you keep thinking of it. "In that sense, you are the universe. You're creating the universe."

From here the Ramhal draws out that God is eternal in the past, before everything, while the world is not. The Rabbi again identified the opposing view as Aristotle's, that God and the universe have always existed together. On the contrary, existence is not natural to anything but God; it is only when He willed it that the space was made for everything else to be built, the planets, the stars and the galaxies.

A digression: other worlds

A participant asked whether God could have made other universes. The Rabbi said there is no reason why not, and we have no idea. Within our universe, he cited Rabbi Aryeh Kaplan's proof that Hazal held there may be life on other planets: in the Song of Devorah the verse says "Curse Meroz", and the Gemara explains Meroz as a star, which suggests it had inhabitants who could be cursed. Outside our universe, "we have absolutely no clue".

The end of §58: does God need His glory?

The Ramhal's last point is one that, the Rabbi said, children often ask. We say that God rejoices in His works and that the world brings Him glory, as Yeshayahu says, "everything I created is for My glory". The Torah describes the korbanot as a pleasing fragrance to God. If the world gives Him joy and glory, did He lack them before? That cannot be.

The Ramhal answers that in God's infinite existence there is no room for creatures at all. Only once He willed existence did creatures gain the ability to bring Him joy and glory. It is His will itself that creates this possibility, and so the system is called incomplete without them. But again, He could remove the whole thing at any time.

The Rabbi offered a careful analogy, warning that we must be cautious with analogies here. A person sometimes makes himself vulnerable to another to encourage him to open up. He can withdraw that vulnerability at any time, but for now he has created a gap that the other person can fill. In a similar sense God created a system in which He wants our kavod, as if we were filling a gap.

Richard suggested another analogy, which the Rabbi called "a great analogy". A beautiful empty patch of land is perfect. Then you dig foundation sockets in it, and now it looks like a mess, full of holes. But you dug them in order to build. You could fill them in and return to the

perfect patch at any time. So too God created a foundation, with gaps that our deeds fill with His glory and joy. And not only the creatures: all the laws by which the world is run, physical and spiritual, also fill those spaces and are needed for the completion of the world.

End of section 3

The Neshamah says: you have explained everything to me well. With that, section 3 is complete. The Rabbi's takeaway: we bring kavod and simhah to God only because He willed that this be possible. All of existence, and all the laws by which it is run, exist only because He wills them, and could be stopped at any time. The next section, starting on page 142, will discuss the relationship between the body and the soul, beginning the following Tuesday.

Summary

- The mode of justice is visible; the mode of unity, God's sovereign override, works hidden within it.
- The perfection God sends into the world is perfect only relative to the world, never His infinite essence.
- §58: nothing but God is a necessary existence, so the world exists only by His continuous will. He is the place of the world.
- Creation brings God joy and glory only because He willed a world in which that is possible; before it He lacked nothing.
- Section 3 ends here; section 4 will turn to the body and the soul.

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